# Part A argument analysis: cram sheet

AP Seminar · end-of-course exam

## The workflow (about 30 minutes, 35 at most)

1. **Read and mark (about 5 min):** C at claims, E at evidence, T at the thesis; circle but, however, should.
2. **Default order A3, A2, A1.** A1 always last; A2 or A3 can go first.
3. **Answer in typed, complete sentences.** Full-score answers aren't flawless prose and have no length target.
4. **Final check (2 min):** every piece tied to a claim, real links, whole thesis, no invented credentials.

## A3: evidence

**6 points · about 11 min**

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| **Verdict** | Short and qualified: mostly effective, partially successful, falls short. |
| **Each piece** | Evidence, the claim it supports, relevance, credibility (author, credentials, organization, date, citation, peer review, possible bias), effect. |
| **Gaps** | May or might limit it; never invent details or flaws. |
| **How many** | About 4 to 5 is a practice target, not a quota. Mix strong and weak. |
| **2025 Sample A** | 6 points: weighed specific evidence from several sources on credibility and relevance, including a study's missing name and year. |

## A2: line of reasoning

**6 points · about 10 min**

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| **Claims** | Major claims, not evidence. |
| **Links** | Builds on, deepens, narrows, qualifies, answers an objection, leads to the solution. |
| **No quota** | No required stages; never invent a pivot. Order is not connection. |
| **2025 Sample A** | 6 points: set up the problem, showed later claims deepening it, grouped benefits by stakeholder, tied each group to the thesis. |
| **Sample B** | 4 points: listed claims in order; linked claims to evidence, not to each other. |

## A1: main argument

**3 points · last, about 2 min**

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| **Whole thesis** | One or two sentences; the topic alone earns 1. Problem plus solution is a common pattern only when the passage has it. |
| **2025 Sample A** | 3 points: caught the policy recommendation, the unequal access under unpaid leave, and the benefits to families. |

## Templates (original; adapt to the passage)

**A3** [Evidence] from [source as described] supports [claim] because [link]. [Detail the passage gives] makes it credible, but [gap the passage shows] limits what it proves. No gap? Drop the “but” clause.

**A2** To build [main argument], the author first establishes [claim]; [next claim] [develops / narrows / deepens] it by [how]; together, [claims] support [main argument] because [why].

**A1** [Author] argues [whole central position] because [main reason(s)], with [essential qualification, if present].

Sample notes paraphrase the College Board’s 2025 Part A Set 1 student samples and commentaries (Sample A responses pp. 9 to 10, commentary pp. 14 to 15); scoring per the 2026 scoring guidelines. Order, piece count and timing are study recommendations, not official rules. A1 to A3: Part A questions 1 to 3; C, claim; E, evidence; T, thesis. valentinoguides.com/seminar-eoc-part-a